

Understand Cholesterol

Cholesterol is a fat-like substance that comes from two sources: **food** and your **body**.

It is only found in foods from animal sources. It travels in the body by lipoproteins (LDL and HDL).

High cholesterol can affect your heart and brain health. It can lead to heart disease and increase the risk of some types of dementia, like Alzheimer's disease.

- **HDL = good:** High-density lipoprotein is known as “**good**” **cholesterol**.
- **LDL = bad:** Low-density lipoprotein is known as “**bad**” **cholesterol**.

HDL helps keep LDL from sticking to artery walls. This reduces plaque buildup and lowers the risk of heart disease and stroke.

Track Levels

- A health care professional can check your cholesterol with a simple blood test and explain what it means for your health.
- Keep track of your cholesterol numbers. If you have high cholesterol, take steps to reduce it.

Tips for Success

- **Eat Smart:** Eat meals with lots of vegetables, fruits, whole grains, beans, nuts, and lean proteins like fish and seafood. Limit sugary foods and drinks, red meats, processed meats, salty snacks, and foods that are highly processed.
- **Move More:** Exercise can help lower cholesterol numbers. It can also improve your mood and clear your mind.
- **Know Your Fats:** The fats you eat can affect your cholesterol numbers. Replace saturated fats like butter and whole dairy products with healthy fats. Healthy fats include olive oil, fatty fish, nuts and eggs.
- **No Nicotine:** Smoking lowers good HDL cholesterol. It also increases your risk of heart disease and affects your brain health.
- **Take Medication as Directed:** Taking your medicine is important. Medicines like statins, or others, can help you control your cholesterol numbers.

Understanding Cholesterol and Lipids: Your Complete Guide to LDL, HDL, Triglycerides and Lipoprotein(a)

Cholesterol plays an important role in your body, but finding the right balance matters for your heart health. Whether you're just learning about cholesterol for the first time or exploring ways to support your heart, we're here to help you discover what works for your life.

Quick Facts About Cholesterol

- Cholesterol comes from two sources. Your liver makes all the cholesterol you need. The rest of the cholesterol in your body comes from food from animals.
- When cholesterol levels stay high over time, it can affect your heart health.
- Many people with high cholesterol do not have symptoms. A simple blood test, also called a lipid panel

Heart-Healthy Diet for Cholesterol Management

- Focus on foods you enjoy, such as colorful fruits and vegetables, nuts, beans, legumes, whole grains, fiber and lean protein (plants, fish, lean meats). Making [healthier recipes](#) doesn't mean giving up flavor.
- Cooking tips for heart health. Start small. You might try swapping one ingredient in a favorite recipe or try one new heart-healthy meal each week. You don't have to sacrifice flavor to eat well for your health. These simple tips for [cooking to lower cholesterol](#) can help you prepare tasty, [heart-healthy recipes](#) that could help improve your cholesterol levels by reducing excess saturated fat and trans fat.
- **Does the keto diet affect cholesterol levels?** Yes. The keto diet can affect cholesterol levels. Very low-carb or keto diets do not typically align with heart-healthy eating guidelines because they are often high in saturated fat. Eating more saturated fat may raise LDL (bad) cholesterol. These diets can also be hard to follow over time and are not more effective for long-term weight loss than less strict eating plans. If you're considering major dietary changes for cholesterol control, talking through options with your health care team can help you find safe, effective approaches.

Physical Activity for Cholesterol

- How does physical activity help lower cholesterol? Moving your body helps bring down LDL (bad) cholesterol and raise HDL (good) cholesterol. When you move more, your body becomes better at clearing out extra cholesterol from your blood. This helps keep your arteries clearer and reduces your risk of heart disease and stroke. Find activities you fully enjoy such as walking, dancing, swimming or even gardening.
- The most effective exercise for lowering cholesterol is the kind you'll actually do consistently. Choose what feels doable for you and build from there. About 150 minutes of moderate-intensity activity weekly can make a difference.